

From RAG to Agentic RAG

When retrieval stops being one step and becomes a loop
the model controls.

PRESENTED BY

DATE

SCOPE

PRESENTER • TEAM

2026.08

INTERNAL

What classic RAG does, and where it stops



ONE PASS · NO FEEDBACK — THE PIPELINE CANNOT LOOK AGAIN

F-01

The question is not the query

The user asks in their words; the corpus is written in someone else's.

F-02

One hop is not enough

An answer that requires joining two documents cannot be retrieved in one shot.

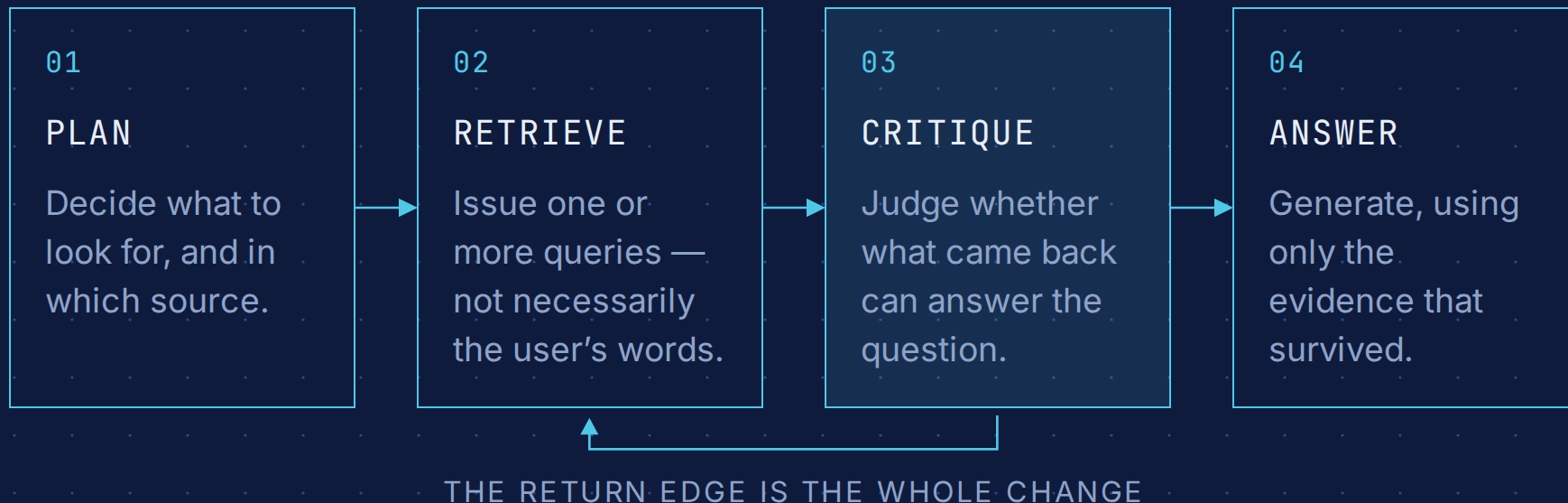
F-03

Nothing can notice the miss

Retrieval always returns its top k. Nothing can say the evidence is not enough.

Classic RAG assumes the first retrieval was the right one. No part of the pipeline is able to disagree.

The shift: retrieval becomes a loop



The model stops being the last step in the pipeline and starts being the thing that drives it.

Patterns you can adopt one at a time

INDEPENDENT — ALL FOUR AT ONCE IS A REWRITE

P-01 Query rewriting

ADDS The index sees a query written for it.

COSTS One extra model call per retrieval.

P-02 Routing

ADDS The right source per question.

COSTS A router to maintain and debug.

P-03 Multi-hop

ADDS Answers that join two documents.

COSTS Latency multiplies by hop count.

P-04 Retrieval grading

ADDS The loop can tell that it failed.

COSTS A judge whose mistakes are yours.

What it costs, and what to decide first

A

WHAT CHANGES

- Latency becomes a distribution
- Token cost scales with attempts
- The same question can take different paths
- Failures become “never stopped”

B

DECIDE BEFORE YOU BUILD

- The stop condition, written down
- A hop budget, and the ceiling behavior
- An eval set with real multi-hop questions
- The fallback path back to one-shot

Agentic RAG trades a predictable pipeline for a system that can recover. Budget the loop before you open it.

Q&A

Three things worth settling before
the next build.

- 01 Which of our failures are retrieval, and which are generation?
- 02 What is our stop condition, and who owns it?
- 03 How would we know the loop got better?

THANK YOU

PRESENTER · TEAM

06

DISCUSSION

SHEET 06/06